

monastery of Cluny and on Gorze in the Rhineland sought to impose a more consistent interpretation of the original monastic “Rule” of St. Benedict. Under the influence of Cluny, Europe’s monasteries merged into more uniform “orders” with a renewed commitment to discipline, prayer, and study.

Other new monastic orders emerged in the period following the Clunaic reforms. In 1098 an abbey was founded at Cîteaux in France that gave its name to one of the most significant of these movements, the Cistercians. Under the influence of the charismatic preacher Bernard of Clairvaux, the Cistercians rejected Cluny’s wealth to focus on manual labor, strict discipline, and austerity. Cistercian monks played a vital

role in the settlement and cultivation of inhospitable and dangerous lands along the borders of medieval Europe.

Papal reform

This reforming impulse also drove the agendas of several influential popes of the late 11th century, who wished to see a Church in which the sacred was more clearly differentiated from the worldly. Popes such as Leo IX (1049–54) sought to limit practices such as clerical marriage and the purchase of church positions (simony). He also attempted to extend papal authority by making ceremonial journeys and summoning bishops to synods (church councils) held at major towns. In his campaign Leo was ably assisted by a group of

The Holy Roman Emperor
Charles IV holds the orb, symbolizing the emperor’s special responsibility for the security of the Church.

King Charles V of France stands to the left of the emperor, representing the other secular rulers of Latin Christendom.

An unidentified noble occupies the final seat, his sword a reminder of his role as a defender of the Church.



The laity fills the right-hand side of the picture, with representative of various secular occupations. The man in white wears a golden garter showing he is a knight and a member of the English Order of the Garter.

Four pilgrims carry the symbols of the major medieval pilgrimage sites: a seashell for Santiago de Compostela, a veil for Rome, and a palm for the Holy Land.

ITALIAN PHILOSOPHER AND THEOLOGIAN (1225–74)

THOMAS AQUINAS

The Italian Dominican friar Thomas Aquinas was the medieval Church’s greatest thinker. His key contribution to theology was to reconcile the newly rediscovered work of the ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle with Christianity. His most important work, *Summa Theologica*, provided a systematic synthesis of Aristotle’s theory and Christian tradition; the result provided the intellectual foundation of the medieval Church and still forms the basis of Catholic doctrine today. A fat and amiable man, the “angelic doctor” was well liked even by his intellectual adversaries. Thomas Aquinas was canonized in 1323.

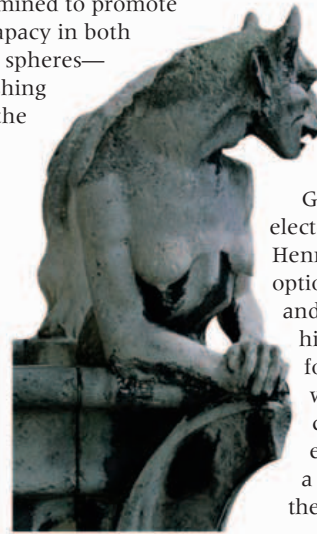


reformers, one of whom, a Clunaic monk named Hildebrand, later became Pope Gregory VII—a key figure in the increasingly powerful papacy.

The investiture controversy

Gregory VII was determined to promote the authority of the papacy in both spiritual and temporal spheres—even if this meant clashing with the authority of the secular kings and princes. In 1075, shortly after he was elected, he composed a detailed statement outlining his status as the spiritual head of Christendom. In it Gregory claimed that, since the pope owed his position to God, he was superior in authority to all earthly rulers.

A major area of dispute between the resurgent papacy and secular rulers was over the appointment (investiture) of bishops and other senior church officials. Since the time of Charlemagne, (see pp.194–95) secular rulers had used their right to be involved in this process to ensure a compliant and sympathetic church. Gregory was determined that control over investiture should lie with the Church and, ultimately, with himself.



Demons and devils

A gargoyle looks out from Notre Dame cathedral, Paris. In the drama of medieval Christendom, demons and devils battled angels and saints.

Matters came to a head in 1076 when Gregory opposed the appointment of the archbishop of Milan by the German emperor Henry IV. A clash between the uncompromising pope and the formidable emperor seemed inevitable.

Henry persuaded the bishops of the German empire to declare the pope deposed; Gregory retaliated by excommunicating (excluding from the Church) Henry. When the German princes rebelled and elected an alternative emperor, Henry decided that he had no option but to do public penance and appeal to the pope to lift his excommunication. After four days of penance, Henry was granted absolution, but conflict between papacy and empire rumbled on. In 1122 a compromise was reached at the Concordat of Worms—but by then the controversy had divided Europe and caused almost half a century of civil war inside Germany.

Popes and antipopes

All over Christendom, the stage was set for a series of clashes between Church and State. In 12th-century England, Henry II clashed with Thomas Becket, Archbishop of Canterbury, about whether clergy should be subject to common law rather than that of the Church. >>

The Church in society

This 14th-century fresco, *The Church Militant and Triumphant* by Andrea da Firenze, presents an idealized view of the medieval social order. Enthroned in the center, the pope presides over the representatives of the Church to his right, and State to his left.

Gothic stone angel

Serene figures such as this one from Reims Cathedral, France, were symbolic of the joys of heaven as well as a consolation for the sufferings of the faithful on earth.

